

Ritual, Humaneness, and the Exemplary Person: An Introduction to Confucius

An original lesson plan inspired by **Jeff Richey's** the Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Confucius. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Jeff Richey. Explore the original course: <https://iep.utm.edu/confucius/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 9-12

DURATION

50 minutes

TOPICS

Eastern Philosophy

“Confucius taught, 'Do not impose on others what you yourself do not desire' — is treating others as you would want to be treated enough, by itself, to make someone a genuinely good person, or does goodness require something more, like cultivated habit and practiced ritual?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Define Confucius's key concepts of ren (humaneness/benevolence), li (ritual propriety), and junzi (the exemplary or superior person).
- Explain how Confucius connects habituated ritual practice (li) to the cultivation of genuine inner virtue (ren), rather than treating good manners and good character as separate things.
- Apply Confucian ideas about ren and reciprocity to evaluate how to handle a realistic modern scenario about treating others well.

Materials Needed

- Handout with 5-6 short, numbered excerpts from the Analects on ren, li, junzi, and reciprocity
- Whiteboard for the opening list-building activity
- Scenario cards for the closing application activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Makes Someone 'Good'?

8 min

Ask students to brainstorm, individually, three qualities of a genuinely good person they know or admire. Collect a range of answers on the board (kind, honest, respectful, disciplined). Note if any answers involve consistent habits or manners specifically, and flag this for later — it previews the connection between li and ren.

Direct Instruction: Ren and Li

13 min

Introduce ren, usually translated humaneness or benevolence, as the inner quality of genuinely caring about and respecting other people. Then introduce li, ritual propriety — the traditional forms of conduct, courtesy, and ceremony governing how people treat each other in different relationships and situations. Explain Confucius's key claim: li is not just empty formality layered on top of a separately-existing goodness; practicing li sincerely and consistently is how a person actually cultivates ren over time, the way practicing an instrument's exercises builds real musicianship rather than just faking it.

Text Analysis: The Analects in Small Groups

15 min

In small groups, students read 2-3 assigned excerpts from the handout, each illustrating ren, li, or the idea of reciprocity ('do not impose on others what you do not desire yourself'). Groups paraphrase each excerpt in their own words and identify which concept (ren, li, or junzi) it best illustrates, then share out to the whole class.

Whole-Class Application

9 min

Present a scenario card (e.g., a friend asks to copy your homework, or a classmate is being excluded from a group project) and ask the class to discuss what a junzi — someone who has genuinely cultivated ren through li — would do in that situation, and why simply following the reciprocity rule alone might not be enough without also having cultivated the right habits and sensitivity.

Closure

5 min

Ask students to write one sentence naming a small ritual or habit of courtesy (a greeting, a way of listening, a habit of thanks) that they think actually helps build genuine good character, not just good manners. Collect a few responses to close.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Confucius connects practicing ritual (li) to developing genuine inner virtue (ren) — do you think good manners can actually build good character over time, or can someone perform all the right rituals while remaining unkind underneath?
- 2 Is 'do not impose on others what you yourself do not desire' a complete guide to treating people well, or can you think of situations where it might give the wrong answer (for instance, if your own desires are unusual)?
- 3 What is the difference between a junzi (exemplary person) and someone who is simply polite or well-behaved out of habit, without really caring about others?
- 4 Confucius emphasizes learning proper conduct within specific relationships (parent-child, ruler-subject, friend-friend) rather than one universal rule for everyone — is this more realistic than a single universal rule, or does it risk excusing unfair treatment within certain relationships?
- 5 Can rituals and traditions from a very different historical period (ancient China) still teach us something useful about character today, or are they too tied to their original context to transfer?

Assessment

Students write a short response explaining, in their own words, how Confucius connects the practice of li (ritual propriety) to the cultivation of ren (humaneness), and then describe one specific habit or small ritual from their own life that they believe helps build good character, applying Confucius's reasoning to explain why.

Extension Activity

Have students observe one family, school, or cultural tradition/ritual in their own life for a day (a greeting custom, a mealtime practice, a form of address for elders) and write a short reflection on what values it seems to be quietly teaching or reinforcing, connecting it back to Confucius's idea that ritual practice shapes character.

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